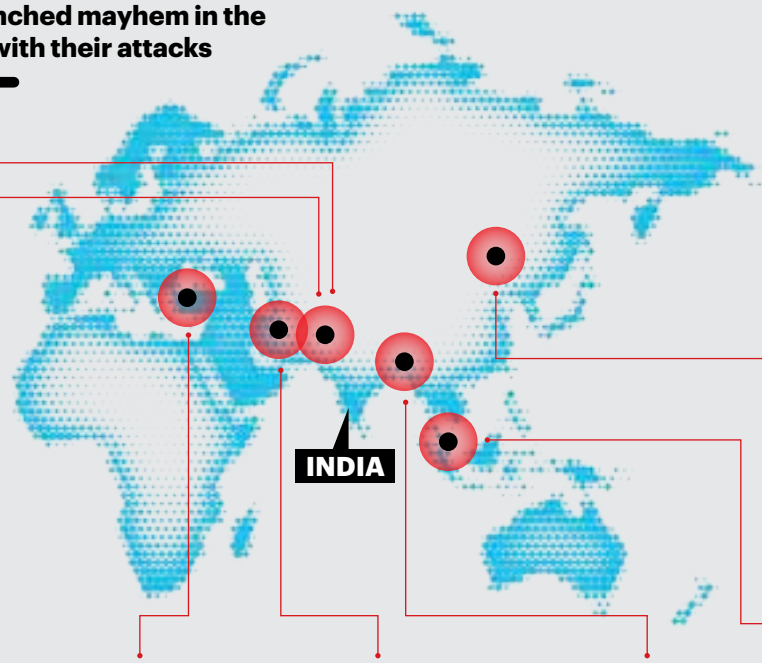
A HACKERS' GALLERY

A few of the foreign hacking groups/ hacktivists who launched mayhem in the Indian cyberspace with their attacks



APT36 (Pakistan)

Also known as Transparent Tribe, it carried out phishing campaigns against armed forces personnel, but failed. Hacked websites of the Military Engineer Services, the Manohar Parrikar Institute and the DRDO

Team Insane Pakistan & HOAX1337 (Pakistan)

Hacked websites of Assam Rifles, Department of Atomic Energy, Armoured Vehicles Nigam Ltd

Turk Hack Team (Turkey)

Carried out unsuccessful DDoS attacks on Indian banking websites and media portals

Vulture (Iran)

Directed DDoS attacks on websites of CERT-In, National Testing Agency, PMO and the President's office

Mysterious Bangladesh

Tried to breach government portals like those of CBI, the Election Commission and BSNL

R3VOX Anonymous (decentralised)

Launched abortive DDoS attacks on the Central Board of Indirect Taxes and Customs and Income Tax Department

APT41 & Mustang Panda (China)

Failed attempts to impair India's power grids, logistics chains and telecommunications networks

RipperSec (Malaysia)

Targeted the vice president of India's website but was repelled

tutes, including the Defence Research and Development Organisation (DRDO), were successfully targeted. Clearly, more needs to be done to beef up India's cyber-security, as attacks on Indian cyber space continue.

Tarun Wig, CEO of Innefu Labs, an agency that works closely with the ministry of defence (MoD), agrees that the attacks are a clarion call for the country's defence mechanism. "These invasions are no longer just for ransom. They target critical infrastructures, steal sensitive data and attempt to disrupt essential services," he says.

BARRAGE OF ATTACKS

Jaijit Bhattacharya, cyber-security expert and president of the Delhi-based Centre for Digital Economy Policy (C-Dep), says that the Pahalgam terrorist attack served as the ignition point for the hybrid war—an orchestrated blend of terrorism and cyber aggression—



"THE PAHALGAM ATTACK IGNITED THE BARRAGE OF CYBER INTRUSIONS. THE IMPLICATIONS WERE SERIOUS—NATIONAL SECURITY, ECONOMIC STABILITY AND CIVIL TRUST IN DIGITAL SYSTEMS WERE UNDER SIEGE"

DR JAIJIT BHATTACHARYA
President, Centre for Digital Economy Policy

unleashed against India, signalled by a storm of attempted cyber intrusions and disruptions. Servers of the MoD, the Election Commission and key financial institutions were targeted, and cyber-security agencies like CERT-In and the National Technical Research Organisation (NTRO), which includes the NCIIPC, raised immediate alarms of an "ongoing coordinated offensive". "The implications were serious—national security, economic stability and civil trust in digital systems were under siege," Bhattacharya adds. Pakistan was the primary actor, while Malaysia and Turkey played subtler roles, he points out.

India's cyber agencies found that Pakistani group APT36 (a.k.a. Transparent Tribe), escalated phishing campaigns targeting armed forces personnel. Malware-laced documents mimicking internal communication were used to try and exfiltrate sensitive information,